

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cybersecurity English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Incident Response and Containment

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

03 Vulnerability Management

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

04 Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

07 Security Awareness and Phishing

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Executive Risk Briefings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

SIEM - Security information and event management: tools that collect and analyze security-related event data.

alert - A notification that an event or condition may need attention.

false positive - A result that flags a condition as present when it is absent under the stated definition.

privileged account - An account with elevated permissions beyond ordinary user access.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An alert is not confirmed account misuse

Fictional security triage using the lesson case: an alert concerns a privileged account, and authorization has not been established.

01 • Security analyst: The monitoring tool raised an alert involving a privileged account. Authorization is still unconfirmed.

02 • SOC lead: What did the security information and event management system, or SIEM, actually observe?

03 • Security analyst: It flagged account activity for review. I haven't checked the relevant authorization record yet.

04 • SOC lead: Then avoid describing the account as compromised simply because the detection rule triggered.

05 • Security analyst: Should I call it a false positive if the account owner says they recognize the activity?

06 • SOC lead: Treat that statement as evidence to verify, not automatic closure. Check it against the recorded event.

07 • Security analyst: I'll preserve the alert details and distinguish the observed activity from the owner's explanation.

08 • SOC lead: Good. Use the established triage process and keep any privileged-account details in the restricted case.

09 • Security analyst: I'll report authorization as unresolved until the review provides a supported conclusion.

10 • SOC lead: Then we can decide the next response step from evidence rather than from the alert label alone.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A travel explanation needs a matched timestamp

Fictional alert review: an account shows a login from an unfamiliar location; the employee mentioned travel, but dates have not been matched.

01 • Service desk analyst: The employee mentioned travel, so can we close the unfamiliar-location alert as a false positive?

02 • Security analyst: First match the travel explanation to the event time. We haven't established that connection yet.

03 • Service desk analyst: The location label itself might also be approximate rather than proof of physical presence.

04 • Security analyst: Correct. It's an observed system label, not a complete explanation of who used the account.

05 • Service desk analyst: What should I hand over without making the employee sound either guilty or automatically cleared?

06 • Security analyst: The event details, the employee's statement, and the unresolved timestamp comparison through the case channel.

07 • Service desk analyst: Should I ask them to send credentials so we can test their explanation directly?

08 • Security analyst: No. Use the approved verification process; credentials don't belong in this investigation conversation.

09 • Service desk analyst: I'll record the explanation as unverified context and keep the alert open for triage.

10 • Security analyst: Thank you. We'll assess authorization using the relevant evidence and avoid unsupported identity claims.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Many alerts may describe one event

Fictional monitoring review: three SIEM alerts reference the same event identifier; their relationship has not been assessed.

01 • Operations manager: Three alerts arrived together. Should I report three separate security incidents to leadership?

02 • Security analyst: Not yet. They reference the same event identifier, so we need to assess their relationship.

03 • Operations manager: Does the shared identifier prove all three are duplicates and can be dismissed?

04 • Security analyst: No. It suggests a connection, but each rule may describe a different aspect of the activity.

05 • Operations manager: Then alert count and incident count are different measures in the triage summary.

06 • Security analyst: Exactly. We have three alerts under investigation, not three independently confirmed incidents.

07 • Operations manager: Can you preserve their rule details while explaining that distinction in plain language?

08 • Security analyst: I'll retain the source records and say several detections may relate to one underlying event.

09 • Operations manager: Please avoid presenting either compromise or false-positive status before the relevant checks are complete.

10 • Security analyst: Agreed. I'll report the observed relationship and the open authorization question at the next checkpoint.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Security Triage and Alert Investigation

A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

Scenario 2 | An administrator recognizes the command name

A fictional privileged-account alert contains a familiar maintenance command name. The administrator recognizes it, but execution time and authorization have not been verified. Discuss what the recognition establishes and what remains open.

Role A: Security analyst: distinguish familiarity from verified authorization.

Role B: System administrator: provide context without requesting automatic closure.

Possible opening: The command name is familiar, but we still need to match this execution to authorized maintenance.

Success checks

- Preserve the observed alert details.
- Do not treat recognition as proof of authorization.
- Agree a controlled verification step.

Add a complication: A manager asks you to mark the alert false positive before the record is checked.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Incident Response and Containment

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A response team receives a suspected incident. The initial report contains a timestamp and affected service but no confirmed cause.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

incident - Unplanned event that disrupts service, safety, quality, security, operations, or expected performance.

containment - Action intended to limit the spread or effect of a problem while it is addressed.

ransomware - Malicious software used to deny access to data or systems and demand payment.

forensics - The collection and examination of evidence to understand an event.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Compare this wording: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Handoff with a timestamp, not a confirmed cause

Separate fictional response handoff: a suspected incident was reported at 09:10 UTC on 8 September 2026 for service DOC-7. The cause and containment status are unconfirmed.

01 • Triage analyst: I'm handing over a suspected incident reported at 09:10 UTC on 8 September 2026 for service DOC-7.

02 • Incident coordinator: Please give me the source report and identify which parts are direct observations versus interpretation.

03 • Triage analyst: The source report identifies DOC-7 and that timestamp. The cause remains unconfirmed and needs investigation.

04 • Incident coordinator: Has containment been authorized or performed, or would that be another assumption in this handoff?

05 • Triage analyst: I haven't verified containment status. I'll mark it unknown rather than imply action occurred.

06 • Incident coordinator: Good. Include the reporting contact so we can clarify that through the established response process.

07 • Triage analyst: I'll keep evidence in the restricted case and avoid relabeling this as ransomware without supporting findings.

08 • Incident coordinator: Please preserve the original record for the forensics team and identify any missing context explicitly.

09 • Triage analyst: Can you confirm receipt of the report and the open cause and containment questions?

10 • Incident coordinator: Received: DOC-7, 09:10 UTC, 8 September 2026. Cause and containment remain unconfirmed; I'll coordinate authorized responders.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A containment request is not a completed action

Fictional incident handoff: a request to isolate a workstation was submitted to authorized responders, but no execution confirmation has arrived.

01 • Security analyst: The isolation request was submitted to the response team, but I haven't received execution confirmation.

02 • Incident lead: Then the handoff must say containment requested, not workstation isolated. Is that your current evidence?

03 • Security analyst: Yes. The request record is available, while the actual containment state remains unconfirmed.

04 • Incident lead: Please identify the receiving responder and the affected asset through the restricted incident record.

05 • Security analyst: I'll include both. Should I infer completion because the request was acknowledged a few minutes later?

06 • Incident lead: No. Acknowledgment confirms receipt, not necessarily action. Ask the authorized team for the actual status.

07 • Security analyst: Understood. I'll also retain the original event references so the forensics review has a traceable starting point.

08 • Incident lead: Good. Avoid making independent operational changes while the response owner coordinates the action.

09 • Security analyst: I'll hand over the evidence links, request history, and unresolved execution confirmation now.

10 • Incident lead: Received. I'll follow up with the responder and report confirmed containment status when it is available.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The handoff crosses a time-zone boundary

Fictional incident transfer: a report says 09:10 without a time zone; the receiving team works in another region, and the source log is available.

01 • Incident coordinator: The report lists nine ten, but it doesn't specify the time zone. Can you clarify?

02 • Monitoring analyst: I need to check the source log. I shouldn't assume it uses my local time.

03 • Incident coordinator: Please preserve the original timestamp and record any conversion explicitly for the receiving team.

04 • Monitoring analyst: I'll do that. Until the check finishes, the event time is incomplete rather than precisely established.

05 • Incident coordinator: Does the report identify the affected service clearly enough for us to locate the right case?

06 • Monitoring analyst: Yes, the service identifier is recorded. I'll include that and the source-log reference in the handoff.

07 • Incident coordinator: Please keep the suspected cause separate; matching timestamps won't establish attribution by itself.

08 • Monitoring analyst: Agreed. The cause remains unconfirmed, and no new containment status has been verified here.

09 • Incident coordinator: I'll acknowledge the case now, with timestamp interpretation and containment status listed as open questions.

10 • Monitoring analyst: Thank you. I'll send the verified time context through the same case channel once checked.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Incident Response and Containment

A response team receives a suspected incident. The initial report contains a timestamp and affected service but no confirmed cause.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: The report identifies the affected service and timestamp; the cause is unconfirmed. Please acknowledge the handoff and use the response process to coordinate investigation and any containment decision.

Scenario 2 | Two asset names may refer to one workstation

A fictional suspected-incident report names workstation LAB-4, while an isolation request names asset 204. Their relationship is unverified. Hand over the mismatch without directing action against either asset.

Role A: Triage analyst: identify the two recorded names and missing mapping.

Role B: Incident coordinator: confirm receipt and route asset verification to the authorized responder.

Possible opening: The report and request use different asset names; we have not verified that they identify the same workstation.

Success checks

- Preserve both identifiers accurately.
- Avoid claiming containment or identity is confirmed.
- Agree a verified asset-mapping handoff.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests assuming the names match to save time.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Vulnerability Management

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

Two vulnerabilities have similar severity scores, but one affects an exposed service and the other an isolated test system.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

CVE - Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures identifier used to reference a publicly known cybersecurity vulnerability.

CVSS - Common Vulnerability Scoring System, a standardized method for expressing the severity and characteristics of a vulnerability.

exploitability - How feasible it is for an attacker to take advantage of a vulnerability.

compensating control - An alternative safeguard used to address risk when another control cannot be applied as intended.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Compare this wording: This option is more better.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Similar severity, different exposure

Fictional vulnerability prioritization using the lesson case: similar severity scores affect an exposed service and an isolated test system.

01 • Infrastructure manager: The two vulnerabilities have similar scores. Should they receive identical remediation priority?

02 • Vulnerability analyst: Not automatically. One affects an exposed service, while the other is on an isolated test system.

03 • Infrastructure manager: So the Common Vulnerability Scoring System, or CVSS, score isn't our complete local risk assessment.

04 • Vulnerability analyst: Correct. Compare exposure, exploitability evidence, asset importance, and verified compensating controls for each case.

05 • Infrastructure manager: Can we assume the isolated system is harmless and postpone it indefinitely?

06 • Vulnerability analyst: No. Isolation is relevant context, not proof of zero risk or a substitute for reviewing its actual state.

07 • Infrastructure manager: Please avoid inventing active exploitation simply because the exposed service sounds more concerning.

08 • Vulnerability analyst: Agreed. I'll separate known exposure from unconfirmed exploitation and check the applicable vulnerability records.

09 • Infrastructure manager: Bring a ranked recommendation with those common criteria and any required remediation approvals.

10 • Vulnerability analyst: I will. The comparison will explain the tradeoff without reducing priority to one score.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A scanner finding needs applicability checks

Fictional assessment: a scanner flags the same vulnerability identifier on two servers; installed component and version evidence is incomplete for one.

01 • Server owner: Both servers show the same Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures identifier, or CVE. Are they equally affected?

02 • Vulnerability analyst: We need applicability evidence. One server's installed component and version record is still incomplete.

03 • Server owner: Would dismissing that finding until inventory is perfect be the simplest prioritization decision?

04 • Vulnerability analyst: No. Keep the unverified finding visible and request the missing inventory information through the normal process.

05 • Server owner: For the confirmed server, should we compare exposure and service importance while that check proceeds?

06 • Vulnerability analyst: Yes. Use the same criteria, but label unknown fields rather than filling them with reassuring assumptions.

07 • Server owner: We also have a claimed compensating control whose current configuration hasn't been verified.

08 • Vulnerability analyst: Then treat that control as unconfirmed, not as a demonstrated reduction in exploitability.

09 • Server owner: I'll supply the inventory record and route the control-verification request to its owner.

10 • Vulnerability analyst: I'll update the comparison when evidence arrives and keep scanner detection separate from confirmed applicability.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Patch availability and service disruption

Fictional remediation planning: two affected services have proposed patches; one has a tested maintenance plan, while the other's recovery plan is unverified.

01 • Operations lead: Both patches are available. Can we schedule both services together and close the vulnerability tickets?

02 • Security engineer: Patch availability isn't completed remediation. One service has a tested maintenance plan; the other's recovery plan is unverified.

03 • Operations lead: Should the unverified plan automatically put that service last, regardless of its exposure?

04 • Security engineer: No. We need to compare exposure and exploitability alongside change risk and recovery readiness.

05 • Operations lead: That creates a tradeoff between addressing security risk quickly and avoiding an unreviewed service change.

06 • Security engineer: Exactly. The authorized change and risk owners should assess the options using verified evidence.

07 • Operations lead: Can a proposed compensating control be listed while recovery planning is completed?

08 • Security engineer: As a proposal, yes. Don't present it as operating protection until its implementation and effect are checked.

09 • Operations lead: I'll bring the readiness gap and maintenance options to the responsible review rather than promise closure.

10 • Security engineer: I'll provide the vulnerability context and distinguish planned patching from verified remediation in the status.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Vulnerability Management

Two vulnerabilities have similar severity scores, but one affects an exposed service and the other an isolated test system.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The scores are similar, but exposure and operational context differ. Let's compare those factors and the available evidence before presenting a remediation priority to the responsible team.

Scenario 2 | The unused service is still running

A fictional system owner calls a vulnerable service unused, but monitoring shows it is running. Network exposure and business dependency are unknown. Compare the claim with the evidence and request the information needed for prioritization.

Role A: Vulnerability analyst: explain why unused is not a verified risk classification.

Role B: System owner: acknowledge unknown dependencies and help locate evidence.

Possible opening: The service is running; we still need to verify exposure and dependencies before prioritizing its remediation.

Success checks

- Separate reported use from verified exposure.
- Compare security and operational criteria.
- Route the decision without directing an unreviewed service shutdown.

Add a complication: The owner asks you to treat no recent support tickets as proof that disabling it has no impact.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A vendor requests a shared privileged account for support. The organization has a controlled access-review process.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

IAM - Identity and access management: processes and systems for managing identities and permissions.

least privilege - Providing only the access needed for an authorized task or role.

MFA - Multi-factor authentication: verifying identity using more than one distinct type of authentication factor.

RBAC - Role-based access control: assigning permissions according to defined roles.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - B. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - C. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - B. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - C. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Request named, reviewed vendor access

Fictional access discussion using the lesson case: a vendor requests a shared privileged account, and the organization has a controlled access-review process.

01 • Vendor coordinator: Our support team wants one shared privileged account so anyone on the shift can help.

02 • IAM analyst: Please submit the named users, required tasks, and requested access period through our access-review process.

03 • Vendor coordinator: Why do you need the tasks instead of simply granting the administrator role we requested?

04 • IAM analyst: Identity and access management, or IAM, needs that context to assess least privilege for the actual work.

05 • Vendor coordinator: Would enabling multifactor authentication, or MFA, settle the shared-account concern by itself?

06 • IAM analyst: It wouldn't answer every question about individual accountability or appropriate permissions. Those still need review.

07 • Vendor coordinator: I'll identify the support tasks and users. Can you guarantee approval before tomorrow's shift?

08 • IAM analyst: I can request a review update, not promise approval or reviewer availability we haven't confirmed.

09 • Vendor coordinator: Please let us know which details are missing so we can respond through the same channel.

10 • IAM analyst: Agreed. We'll keep the request specific and avoid treating submission as approved privileged access.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A temporary role without an end date

Fictional access request: an employee needs temporary reporting access for a project, but the request does not specify tasks or duration.

01 • Project lead: Please give our analyst the temporary reporting role. We need the access for a project.

02 • Access administrator: Could you specify the reporting tasks and requested end date so the owner can review the scope?

03 • Project lead: The project schedule is still being agreed. Should I just request permanent access for convenience?

04 • Access administrator: Let's preserve that uncertainty and ask for a reviewed duration rather than silently change temporary into permanent.

05 • Project lead: Do you also need to know whether the analyst must view reports or change their configuration?

06 • Access administrator: Yes. Role-based access control, or RBAC, assigns permissions through roles, and those tasks may need different scopes.

07 • Project lead: I'll clarify the actual tasks and ask the project owner about the access period today.

08 • Access administrator: Please include the business purpose and required review timing without assuming the requested role will be approved.

09 • Project lead: Understood. We can track the request as pending while the owner checks the least-privilege fit.

10 • Access administrator: I'll confirm receipt and return any missing-information questions through the controlled access channel.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Check task needs before copying access

Fictional access review: a manager proposes copying a departing colleague's role for a replacement; task equivalence has not been checked.

01 • Team manager: Can you copy the departing colleague's access to the replacement so onboarding is faster?

02 • IAM reviewer: Please identify the replacement's actual tasks first. We haven't established that both roles need identical permissions.

03 • Team manager: They have the same job title. Isn't that enough to select the existing access profile?

04 • IAM reviewer: A title is useful context, but it doesn't verify every permission or any historical access exceptions.

05 • Team manager: Then I'll ask the system owners to confirm which functions are needed for the new assignment.

06 • IAM reviewer: Thank you. Include the requested start timing so the review can be coordinated realistically.

07 • Team manager: Would an existing MFA setup mean the permission review can be skipped for this account?

08 • IAM reviewer: No. Authentication and authorization answer different questions: who signs in and what they may do.

09 • Team manager: I'll submit the task-based request and keep any additional permissions pending owner review.

10 • IAM reviewer: I'll check the role mapping against that scope rather than reproduce unverified access by inheritance.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

A vendor requests a shared privileged account for support. The organization has a controlled access-review process.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you specify the tasks, users, and access period required? We'll submit the request through the access-review process so the appropriate scope and accountability can be assessed.

Scenario 2 | View access for a one-hour demonstration

A fictional trainer needs to demonstrate a report for one hour. The request asks for editing rights, although no editing task is specified. The session is next week. Request clarification through access review without granting permissions.

Role A: IAM analyst: ask what demonstration actions require editing.

Role B: Trainer: explain the intended viewing task and revise the requested scope.

Possible opening: Could you clarify which demonstration task needs editing rights rather than report viewing?

Success checks

- Connect permissions to stated tasks.
- Specify purpose and requested duration.
- Keep approval with the access owner.

Add a complication: The trainer asks for broad access in case an unplanned task appears.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A threat-model discussion lists technologies but does not identify the data flows or trust boundaries.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

threat model - A structured description of possible threats to a system and relevant design protections.

attack surface - Set of systems, interfaces, identities, and entry points an attacker could attempt to exploit.

trust boundary - A point where data or activity crosses between areas with different trust or access assumptions.

abuse case - A description of how someone could misuse a system to cause an unwanted outcome.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

List the data flows, not only technologies

Fictional threat-model review using the lesson case: a diagram lists technologies but does not identify data flows or trust boundaries.

01 • Security designer: The diagram lists technologies. Could you show what data moves between them and who controls each endpoint?

02 • Application architect: Those flows aren't drawn yet. I assumed naming the database and web service was enough.

03 • Security designer: For this threat model, we need to understand where data crosses a trust boundary.

04 • Application architect: You mean where one component cannot simply assume another source is authorized or trustworthy?

05 • Security designer: Yes. Please identify the actual sources, destinations, and checks rather than leave that relationship implicit.

06 • Application architect: Should we invent likely flows from a typical architecture while the owner is unavailable?

07 • Security designer: No. Mark missing information and ask the owner; guessed flows could misdirect the review.

08 • Application architect: I'll bring the verified flow descriptions and identify which interactions remain undocumented.

09 • Security designer: Then we can discuss relevant abuse cases and attack surface without pretending the technology list is complete.

10 • Application architect: Agreed. The next review will start from confirmed interactions, with unknown boundaries clearly labeled.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Who can send the webhook?

Fictional secure-design discussion: a service receives partner webhooks, but sender verification and receiving actions are undocumented.

01 • Threat-model facilitator: Who can send a webhook to this endpoint, and what action does a received message trigger?

02 • Service developer: The design says partner webhook, but it doesn't document sender verification or the resulting action.

03 • Threat-model facilitator: Then partner is an intended source, not evidence that the service verifies that source.

04 • Service developer: Could we mark this trust boundary as protected because the endpoint name isn't advertised publicly?

05 • Threat-model facilitator: No. We need the actual authorization and validation design, not an assumption based on obscurity.

06 • Service developer: I'll ask the integration owner for the data flow and the checks before any action occurs.

07 • Threat-model facilitator: Please also clarify what data is stored and which downstream component receives it.

08 • Service developer: That will let us discuss an abuse case without constructing one from missing architecture details.

09 • Threat-model facilitator: Exactly. We're identifying questions about the attack surface, not claiming a confirmed exploitable vulnerability.

10 • Service developer: I'll return with verified design details and keep the unknown checks explicit until then.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An internal upload still crosses a boundary

Fictional document-tool design: employees upload files to a shared processing service; file origins and processing permissions have not been mapped.

01 • Application owner: Only employees use the upload tool. Do we still need to describe a trust boundary?

02 • Security architect: Yes. Could you clarify where files originate and what the processing service can do with them?

03 • Application owner: We haven't mapped that. Internal users may upload files obtained elsewhere, but the actual sources are unrecorded.

04 • Security architect: Then internal access doesn't establish every file's trustworthiness or the appropriate processing permissions.

05 • Application owner: Should the threat model distinguish user authorization from the content being processed?

06 • Security architect: Exactly. They are related but separate questions, and we need the real data flow for both.

07 • Application owner: I'll ask the service owner which storage and downstream operations are involved before proposing controls.

08 • Security architect: Please keep the abuse-case discussion at the design-review level and identify missing facts rather than invent them.

09 • Application owner: I'll bring a verified flow description with uncertain origins and permissions clearly marked.

10 • Security architect: Then we can assess the relevant attack surface using the actual system boundaries.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Threat Modeling and Secure Design

A threat-model discussion lists technologies but does not identify the data flows or trust boundaries.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which data crosses each boundary, and who can interact with it? Let's map those flows so the discussion connects possible threats to the actual design.

Scenario 2 | A report link leaves the application

A fictional application sends users to an external report viewer. The design names the viewer but does not say which identifiers appear in the link or who can open it. Clarify the data flow and access boundary.

Role A: Security reviewer: ask about link contents, destination, and access checks.

Role B: Product architect: distinguish known routing from undocumented authorization.

Possible opening: Which information leaves our application in that report link, and who can use it at the destination?

Success checks

- Identify the actual outgoing data question.
- Do not equate reputation with verified authorization.
- Agree who will confirm destination access behavior.

Add a complication: A colleague says the viewer is reputable, so no boundary review is needed.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

An audit action is marked closed because a policy was written. Evidence that the control operates is still missing.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

control - A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

audit evidence - Records, observations, or other information used to support an audit conclusion.

risk acceptance - An authorized decision to retain a stated risk under specified conditions.

remediation - Work to correct a problem or reduce its effects; in environmental work, addressing contamination.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Compare this wording: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team plans to complete the review.
 - B. The team has completed the review.
 - C. The team is completing the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.
 - B. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - C. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Written policy, missing operating evidence

Fictional audit review using the lesson case: an action is marked closed because a policy exists, but evidence that the control operates is missing.

01 • Audit coordinator: The action is marked closed because the policy was written. Where is evidence that the control operates?

02 • Control owner: We have the approved text, but we haven't supplied operating records for the review period.

03 • Audit coordinator: Then policy completion is established, while control-operation evidence remains pending. Those statuses should be separate.

04 • Control owner: Does that mean the control definitely failed, or just that we haven't demonstrated its operation?

05 • Audit coordinator: Here the evidence is missing. We shouldn't turn that gap into either verified effectiveness or confirmed failure.

06 • Control owner: I'll reopen the evidence item and identify which records the reviewer requires for assessment.

07 • Audit coordinator: Please use the agreed audit process and preserve the policy version alongside the operating evidence.

08 • Control owner: Could a risk-acceptance note replace the missing records and let us close remediation automatically?

09 • Audit coordinator: Not automatically. Any acceptance requires the appropriate authority and does not invent evidence of operation.

10 • Control owner: Understood. I'll report policy complete, evidence pending, and closure awaiting the responsible review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A screenshot without a review period

Fictional control assessment: a current settings screenshot is available, but the audit asks about operation over the previous quarter.

01 • Control owner: I attached today's settings screenshot. Can the quarterly operating-evidence request now be closed?

02 • Assurance analyst: The screenshot shows a current configuration, not necessarily how the control operated throughout the requested quarter.

03 • Control owner: So the artifact is useful, but it doesn't cover the entire evidence period by itself.

04 • Assurance analyst: Correct. We need to confirm what records support that period under the agreed assessment scope.

05 • Control owner: Would saying the configuration probably stayed unchanged be enough to bridge the missing months?

06 • Assurance analyst: No. That is an assumption, not period-specific audit evidence. Keep the coverage gap visible.

07 • Control owner: I'll ask the record owner for available historical evidence and identify any unrecoverable gaps.

08 • Assurance analyst: Please keep today's screenshot as current-state evidence rather than discarding it or mislabeling its date.

09 • Control owner: I'll update the remediation status to show evidence collection incomplete, without claiming the control failed.

10 • Assurance analyst: Then the reviewer can assess actual coverage and decide what remains necessary for closure.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Risk acceptance is requested, not approved

Fictional governance update: remediation is deferred in a proposal, and a risk-acceptance request has been submitted but not approved.

01 • Project lead: We submitted the risk-acceptance request. Can I say the remaining risk is formally accepted?

02 • Risk analyst: Not yet. Submission is complete, but the authorized decision is still pending.

03 • Project lead: The proposal explains why remediation would take longer. Doesn't that establish a valid deferral?

04 • Risk analyst: It provides a rationale for review, not approval by itself. The decision owner must assess it.

05 • Project lead: Then our status should distinguish the remediation proposal from the governance decision it needs.

06 • Risk analyst: Exactly. Also keep existing controls and evidence gaps visible so the reviewer sees the current position.

07 • Project lead: Could I mark the action closed while leaving a note that acceptance is awaiting signature?

08 • Risk analyst: That would imply closure before the required review. Use the actual pending status instead.

09 • Project lead: I'll correct the update and ask the decision owner for a review checkpoint, not a guaranteed approval.

10 • Risk analyst: Good. The report will reflect completed submission and unresolved acceptance without conflating the two.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Governance, Risk, and Compliance

An audit action is marked closed because a policy was written. Evidence that the control operates is still missing.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: The policy is complete, but evidence of operation is still outstanding. I'll distinguish the documented design from implementation evidence before we report the action's status.

Scenario 2 | Training invitations sent; completion unverified

A fictional audit action requires reviewed evidence of staff training completion. Invitations were sent to 20 staff, but completion records have not been checked. Explain what is complete and what remains pending.

Role A: Control owner: report invitations sent without claiming completion.

Role B: Audit coordinator: request the relevant completion evidence and review scope.

Possible opening: The invitations went to twenty staff, but completion evidence has not yet been checked.

Success checks

- Separate assignment from completion.
- Do not infer attendance or understanding from silence.
- Agree evidence collection and review ownership.

Add a complication: A manager says no complaints about the invitation proves everyone completed training.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Security Awareness and Phishing

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A staff member reports a suspicious message and worries about being blamed. The report has not yet been assessed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

phishing - Deceptive communication intended to induce disclosure, access, or another harmful action.

social engineering - Manipulating people into revealing information or taking actions that compromise security.

reporting culture - Shared expectations that encourage people to raise concerns and report relevant events.

security awareness - Understanding relevant security risks and how to respond through appropriate processes.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
 - B. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - C. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.
 - B. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - C. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Thank the reporter without declaring a verdict

Fictional awareness exchange using the lesson case: an employee reports a suspicious message and fears blame; the message is unassessed.

01 • Department coordinator: I reported a suspicious message, but the reply sounded as though I had caused a security incident.

02 • Security awareness lead: I'm sorry the reply implied blame. Reporting a concern is helpful, and this message hasn't been assessed yet.

03 • Department coordinator: So you're not saying that my report proves I fell for phishing or caused damage?

04 • Security awareness lead: Correct. We need the relevant facts through the reporting process before drawing any conclusion.

05 • Department coordinator: What should the corrected response say so colleagues aren't discouraged from speaking up?

06 • Security awareness lead: Thank you for reporting; the team will assess the message and ask for any needed details.

07 • Department coordinator: Should I forward it widely to warn everyone while the assessment is still pending?

08 • Security awareness lead: Please use the established reporting channel rather than spreading the suspicious content unnecessarily.

09 • Department coordinator: I'll keep the report there and describe only what I observed, without guessing its intent.

10 • Security awareness lead: Thank you. A supportive reporting culture depends on useful evidence and clear communication, not premature blame.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A simulation result should not become a public accusation

Fictional awareness program: a draft summary names an employee as careless after one training simulation interaction; the interaction details have not been reviewed.

01 • Training manager: The draft calls one employee careless after a simulation interaction. Is that an appropriate awareness message?

02 • Security educator: No. It assigns a personal trait from limited evidence and could discourage future reporting.

03 • Training manager: I intended to highlight the learning opportunity, but the wording makes it sound like public blame.

04 • Security educator: Let's correct it to describe the observed interaction and the support available, within appropriate privacy boundaries.

05 • Training manager: We haven't reviewed the interaction details yet. Should we say the employee entered credentials?

06 • Security educator: Not without evidence. Keep the behavior unspecified until the authorized reviewer confirms what actually occurred.

07 • Training manager: I'll remove the name from the broad summary and ask the program owner to review the wording.

08 • Security educator: Good. Security awareness should help people recognize social engineering and report concerns without unsupported accusations.

09 • Training manager: The corrected summary will describe the training topic and next learning step, not an individual's character.

10 • Security educator: I'll review it for factual accuracy and a reporting culture that encourages useful questions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Correcting an all-clear before assessment

Fictional service-desk exchange: a suspicious message was called safe because it displayed a familiar sender name; assessment is still pending.

01 • Office manager: Your first reply said the message was safe because the sender name looked familiar. Is that confirmed?

02 • Security analyst: No. That reassurance was premature, and I apologize. The displayed name alone doesn't establish legitimacy.

03 • Office manager: Then should I tell everyone that it is definitely phishing instead of repeating the all-clear?

04 • Security analyst: Not yet. The assessment is pending, so neither definite label is supported by our current evidence.

05 • Office manager: Please give me a corrected message that doesn't create another unsupported claim for the team.

06 • Security analyst: The earlier all-clear was unverified; the message is being assessed through the security reporting process.

07 • Office manager: Should colleagues keep sending copies to one another to compare what they received?

08 • Security analyst: Ask them to use the established reporting channel and follow the response team's guidance instead.

09 • Office manager: I'll correct the reassurance and thank the colleague who questioned it rather than blame them.

10 • Security analyst: Thank you. I'll provide the assessed outcome when available and keep uncertainty explicit meanwhile.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Security Awareness and Phishing

A staff member reports a suspicious message and worries about being blamed. The report has not yet been assessed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: Thank you for reporting it. Please use the designated channel to share the relevant details. We'll focus on assessing the message and the next steps rather than making assumptions about blame.

Scenario 2 | The employee reported late

A fictional employee reports a suspicious message the next morning and says they delayed because a previous response felt blaming. The message and any effect are unassessed. Repair the communication and encourage factual reporting.

Role A: Security awareness lead: acknowledge the discouraging earlier response without promising an outcome.

Role B: Team administrator: explain the reporting delay and ask what information to provide.

Possible opening: I'm sorry the earlier response discouraged you; thank you for bringing this report to us now.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the communication problem.
- Avoid assumptions about compromise or blame.
- Guide the factual report into the established channel.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to focus the conversation on punishment before assessing the message.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Executive Risk Briefings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A budget proposal describes many technical weaknesses but never explains their possible business effects.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

residual risk - The risk remaining after controls or other responses are applied.

threat actor - A person or group capable of pursuing actions that threaten a system or organization.

maturity - The degree to which a process or capability is developed and consistently practiced.

investment ask - A specific request for funding or resources, supported by a stated purpose and rationale.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Translate weaknesses into possible business effects

Separate fictional executive briefing: restoration of the booking service has not been tested. A proposed restoration exercise needs staff time; potential outage duration and the exercise's benefit are unverified.

01 • Executive sponsor: Restoration of our booking service hasn't been tested. What business effect could that weakness have?

02 • Security manager: Untested restoration could prolong an outage, leaving staff unable to make bookings; the possible duration is unknown.

03 • Executive sponsor: Has that prolonged outage actually occurred, or are you describing a possible consequence of the untested restoration?

04 • Security manager: It's a risk scenario, not a confirmed incident. The proposed exercise would examine restoration readiness; its benefit remains unverified.

05 • Executive sponsor: Please explain residual risk in language that doesn't imply spending removes every possible threat.

06 • Security manager: Residual risk is what remains after the proposed measures; the investment would not make risk disappear.

07 • Executive sponsor: Does improved security maturity guarantee that no threat actor succeeds?

08 • Security manager: No. More consistent practices can improve capability without guaranteeing protection against every event.

09 • Executive sponsor: What specific investment are you asking us to consider, without guaranteeing faster recovery or complete protection?

10 • Security manager: Staff time for a bounded restoration exercise. It could reveal readiness gaps, but we haven't verified recovery improvement.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A capability score is not incident probability

Fictional executive review: a security maturity assessment gives a low documentation score; a leader interprets it as a measured probability of attack.

01 • Operations executive: Our documentation maturity score is low. Does that mean an attack is likely this month?

02 • Security lead: The score assesses a practice area under that framework, not the probability of an attack this month.

03 • Operations executive: Then explain what the score tells us that is useful for an investment decision.

04 • Security lead: It identifies inconsistent documentation in the assessment. We should connect that gap to specific operational consequences.

05 • Operations executive: Could the proposal claim those consequences have already caused incidents if no such evidence is available?

06 • Security lead: No. We should distinguish observed practice gaps from possible effects and any verified incident history.

07 • Operations executive: What does an improvement request look like without promising a numerical reduction we cannot support?

08 • Security lead: A bounded action, an owner, and evidence that the practice becomes more consistent, with residual risk stated.

09 • Operations executive: I'll assess that request more easily than a score presented as a forecast of imminent attack.

10 • Security lead: I'll make the distinction explicit and avoid turning the maturity rating into an unsupported probability.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Funding a control does not eliminate exposure

Fictional budget discussion: a proposed monitoring improvement could shorten detection work, but effect estimates and remaining gaps are not yet verified.

01 • Finance partner: If we fund the monitoring improvement, can we tell leadership that this security risk is eliminated?

02 • Security program manager: No. The proposal concerns detection capability, and its effect estimates still need validation.

03 • Finance partner: Could you explain detection versus prevention before we compare this with the other investment requests?

04 • Security program manager: Detection helps identify concerning activity; prevention aims to stop specified activity. This proposal should not claim both automatically.

05 • Finance partner: Then the business case needs to say which workflow improves and which exposure remains afterward.

06 • Security program manager: Exactly. I'll describe the intended response benefit, assumptions, and residual risk without inventing guaranteed incident savings.

07 • Finance partner: Does the proposal identify a particular threat actor as responsible for a past event?

08 • Security program manager: No attribution is established here. We should not use an actor label as proof of the investment's value.

09 • Finance partner: Bring the bounded investment ask and how we would evaluate the expected capability improvement.

10 • Security program manager: I'll do that, keeping the proposed benefit distinct from verified performance and complete risk removal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Executive Risk Briefings

A budget proposal describes many technical weaknesses but never explains their possible business effects.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: I'll connect each issue to the affected service, plausible consequence, and proposed response. That will help leaders compare the investment request with the risk it is intended to address.

Scenario 2 | A tabletop exercise is not a restored service

A fictional response team completed a discussion-based exercise. No live service restoration was performed or measured. An executive wants to announce proven rapid recovery. Explain the exercise result and the remaining evidence gap.

Role A: Security manager: explain what the exercise practiced.

Role B: Executive sponsor: ask what would support a recovery-capability claim.

Possible opening: The exercise practiced decisions and coordination; it did not measure restoration of a live service.

Success checks

- Distinguish discussion practice from measured restoration.
- Do not invent a recovery-time claim.
- Identify the next evidence question and remaining uncertainty.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks for a recovery-time figure derived from the meeting length.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Incident Response and Containment

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: The report identifies the affected service and timestamp; the cause is unconfirmed. Please acknowledge the handoff and use the response process to coordinate investigation and any containment decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Vulnerability Management

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The scores are similar, but exposure and operational context differ. Let's compare those factors and the available evidence before presenting a remediation priority to the responsible team.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: A - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

B: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

C: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

Check 2: C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

B: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

C: The requested action and information are explicit.

Model response: Could you specify the tasks, users, and access period required? We'll submit the request through the access-review process so the appropriate scope and accountability can be assessed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Which data crosses each boundary, and who can interact with it? Let's map those flows so the discussion connects possible threats to the actual design.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: B - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

B: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

C: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

Check 2: A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

B: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

C: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

Model response: The policy is complete, but evidence of operation is still outstanding. I'll distinguish the documented design from implementation evidence before we report the action's status.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Security Awareness and Phishing

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

B: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

C: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

Check 2: C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: The reader still lacks the information they need.

B: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

C: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

Model response: Thank you for reporting it. Please use the designated channel to share the relevant details. We'll focus on assessing the message and the next steps rather than making assumptions about blame.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Executive Risk Briefings

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: I'll connect each issue to the affected service, plausible consequence, and proposed response. That will help leaders compare the investment request with the risk it is intended to address.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Cybersecurity English

Professional audience: security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Original fictional case: A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: SIEM: Security information and event management: tools that collect and analyze security-related event data. / alert: A notification that an event or condition may need attention. / false positive: A result that flags a condition as present when it is absent under the stated definition. / privileged account: An account with elevated permissions beyond ordinary user access.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level